

PRACTITIONER FIELD GUIDE

Turkish Export Operations

A field guide for Export Sales Specialists and Foreign Trade Specialists

End-to-end operations from enquiry to VAT refund, written from the seat of a Turkish exporter.

Turkey · Russia · United States · United Kingdom · European Union · China

An independent professional guide

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Foreword

This guide exists because the distance between knowing international trade and doing it is measured in mistakes. Most of those mistakes are cheap the first time and expensive the second.

Who this is for

You have studied international trade, or you have just been handed an export desk, or both. You can define an Incoterm and describe a letter of credit. What you do not yet have is the thing that separates a five-year veteran from a well-read beginner: **the ability to see, in the first ninety seconds of a problem, which way it is going to go and what it will cost.**

That ability is not mysterious. It is pattern recognition built from repetition — the same discrepancy rejected by the same bank for the same reason, the same carrier going quiet on the same day of the week, the same customer asking for DDP without knowing what they are asking for. This guide is an attempt to compress that repetition into something you can read.

How the guide is built

Every chapter starts with the logic and then descends into the procedure, because a procedure you do not understand is a procedure you cannot defend when a customer, a forwarder or a bank pushes back. Where the reasoning matters more than the steps, you will find a **Field note**. Where the cost of an error is high, a **Watch out**. Where a real situation teaches more than an explanation, a **Case study**.

- **Chapters 1 and 2** follow the two job functions — export sales and foreign trade operations — through a full order cycle.
- **Chapter 3** is the documentation reference: what each document proves, who issues it, and how it fails.
- **Chapter 4** is a country desk: Turkey, Russia, the United States, the United Kingdom, the European Union and China.
- **Chapter 5** covers SAP as it is actually used on an export desk, not as it is described in training material.
- **Chapter 6** is about risk and the specific ways export operations go wrong.

Three warnings about using it

Regulations move. Tariff lines, incentive rates, sanctions listings and documentary requirements change on a timescale of weeks. Every rule in this guide that can change is marked with its primary source. Treat the guide as a map of where to look, never as the current text of the law. Before you rely on a figure or a listing, open the source.

Compliance is not an obstacle to be routed around. Chapter 4 covers sanctions and export controls in some detail, because a Turkish exporter today cannot avoid them. It covers how to establish that a transaction is lawful, how to document that determination, and when to stop. It does not cover how to move goods or money that are prohibited, and no competent operations department does either — the exposure runs to the company, its banks and the individuals who signed.

Your company's procedure wins. Where this guide and your internal quality system disagree, follow the quality system and raise the difference with whoever owns it. A field guide cannot know your ERP configuration, your insurance policy or your customs broker's working habits.

FIELD NOTE How to read the country flags in this guide

Throughout, **TR** marks a Turkish rule that binds you directly; **RU / US / UK / EU / CN** mark a foreign requirement that reaches you through the contract or through your buyer. The distinction matters: you can be fined for the first, but you will only lose the shipment, the payment or the customer for the second

— which is often worse.

CHAPTER 1

Export Sales Operations

The export sales desk is where a commercial promise becomes an operational obligation. Everything that later goes wrong in logistics, documentation or payment was, in most cases, decided here — in a quotation written in four minutes, an Incoterm chosen by habit, or an order confirmation that repeated the customer's wording instead of the seller's.

This chapter follows one order from enquiry to closure and shows, at each step, what an experienced specialist is protecting.

By the end of this chapter you should be able to

- Build a quotation whose price still holds when freight, packing and payment terms are added.
- Convert an enquiry into an order confirmation that will survive a dispute.
- Run the weekly shipment rhythm without letting a single order fall between departments.
- Recognise the four moments in an order cycle where silence is a warning sign.

1.1 What the desk actually owns

On paper, export sales receives orders and issues documents. In practice the desk owns a single, unglamorous thing: **the promise date**. Every other department optimises its own constraint. You are the only person whose job is the customer's delivery.

That framing decides how you spend your day. Production plans capacity; shipping books space; finance protects cash. None of them is wrong, and none of them is looking at the whole line from purchase order to arrival. When you understand that the desk exists to hold that line, the apparently administrative parts of the role — chasing a proforma signature, confirming a cut-off, re-reading a letter of credit — stop looking like paperwork and start looking like what they are: the points where the promise can quietly break.

Table 1.1 — The order cycle and what is at stake at each stage

Stage	Who leads	What can silently go wrong	Cost if missed
Enquiry and quotation	Export sales	Freight or packing excluded; validity period omitted	Margin, or an unwinnable renegotiation
Order entry and confirmation	Export sales	Customer PO terms silently accepted	Contractual exposure on delivery and payment
Production slotting	Planning	Order accepted for a week with no capacity	Late shipment, penalty, roll-over
Freight booking	Foreign trade	Space booked without matching the ready date	Demurrage, detention, missed vessel
Documentation	Export sales / foreign trade	Document set built from the invoice, not the L/C	Discrepancy, delayed or lost payment
Customs clearance	Broker	HS code or origin claim unverified	Line inspection, fine, retroactive duty at destination
Post-shipment	Export sales	Arrival not tracked; claim window missed	Uncovered damage, unrecoverable claim
Closure	Foreign trade / finance	Declaration not closed in the tax system	Blocked VAT refund

The right-hand column is the one to memorise. It is the argument you will use when you need another department to move.

1.2 Quotation: the price that has to survive

A quotation is not a price. It is a price attached to a delivery term, a validity period, a payment method, a packing specification and a lead time — and it is only as strong as its weakest attachment. The most common failure on a junior desk is a number that is correct in isolation and indefensible in context.

1.2.1 Build the price in layers

Work outward from the ex-works cost, and never quote a delivery term whose costs you have not actually listed. The discipline matters more than the arithmetic: it is the listing, not the adding, that catches the omission.

- 1. Ex-works cost.** Goods, export packing, marking and palletising. Export packing is not domestic packing; if your factory quotes domestic, you are already short.
- 2. Inland leg.** Factory to port or border, including loading, waiting time and any escort or permit for out-of-gauge cargo.

3. **Origin charges.** Terminal handling, documentation fee, seal, VGM, customs brokerage, and the exporters' association registration fee.
4. **Main carriage.** Ocean or road freight for the specific equipment type, plus current surcharges — bunker, congestion, war risk, low-sulphur, peak season.
5. **Destination charges, if your term reaches that far.** Terminal handling at destination, customs clearance, duty and import taxes for DDP.
6. **Money costs.** Letter of credit confirmation and negotiation fees, forward cover if you are quoting in a currency you do not hold, and the cost of the credit period you are granting.
7. **Risk margin.** Not padding: a named allowance for the things that have historically gone wrong on this lane.

WATCH OUT The three quotation omissions that cost the most

- **No validity period.** A price without an expiry is a price forever. Freight rates on a single lane can move by half in a quarter; a quotation issued in a soft market and accepted in a tight one is a loss you agreed to in writing. State a validity, and state that freight is subject to reconfirmation at booking.
- **No packing specification.** "Standard export packing" means whatever the buyer imagines. When the buyer imagines sea-worthy crates and you shipped shrink-wrapped pallets, the damage claim is yours to argue.
- **A delivery term chosen to sound generous.** DDP quoted to a market whose import duties and VAT registration rules you have not checked is the single most expensive habit on a junior desk. See §1.2.2.

1.2.2 Choosing the delivery term, and what each one really costs you

Incoterms 2020 allocate cost, risk and obligation between seller and buyer. They are not shipping instructions and they are not payment terms, and the most common commercial errors come from treating them as either. Three questions decide the term: **where does my risk end, who is better placed to clear customs at each end, and whose freight rate is better.**

Table 1.2 — Delivery terms from the Turkish seller's seat

Term	Risk passes	What it costs the seller in practice
EXW	At your premises	Simplest, and often the wrong answer: you still need the export declaration in your name to obtain the exit record for a VAT refund. Prefer FCA.
FCA	On delivery to the buyer's carrier	The safe default for containerised cargo. Export clearance is yours, main carriage is theirs. In FCA the buyer can instruct the carrier to issue an on-board bill of lading to you — useful under a letter of credit.
FOB	On board the vessel	Widely used and widely misused. For containers handed over at a terminal days before loading, FOB leaves you carrying risk you cannot control. Use FCA instead.
CFR / CIF	On board the vessel; you pay carriage (and, in CIF, insurance)	Your cost runs past your risk. CIF requires only Institute Cargo Clauses (C) as a minimum — a narrow cover that surprises buyers who expected all-risks.
CPT / CIP	On handover to the first carrier; you pay carriage (and, in CIP, insurance)	The multimodal equivalents. Note the 2020 change: CIP now requires Institute Cargo Clauses (A) as a minimum, CIF still (C).
DAP / DPU	At the named destination	You carry the main carriage risk to destination. Import clearance

Term	Risk passes	What it costs the seller in practice
	(DPU: after unloading)	stays with the buyer, which is what keeps this manageable.
DDP	At destination, cleared for import	You accept import duty, import VAT and, in several markets, an obligation you may not legally be able to meet as a non-resident. Quote it only after checking the destination's rules.

Source: ICC Incoterms® 2020. The rules are a copyright text; buy the current edition and keep it on the desk — a summary table is an aid to memory, not an authority.

FIELD NOTE Why an experienced desk resists DDP

DDP moves the import clearance to you, and import clearance is usually reserved to a resident or registered party. In much of the EU a non-established seller cannot act as importer of record without a fiscal representative or a local VAT registration; in the United Kingdom you will need a GB EORI and a route for import VAT; in Russia the customs declarant must generally be a Russian person. The result is that DDP is quoted, accepted, and then delivered as DAP with the seller paying charges through the forwarder — an arrangement with no contractual clarity and no recoverable import VAT.

When a buyer insists on DDP, the professional answer is not refusal. It is: *"We can deliver DAP to your door and quote the duty and import VAT separately as an estimate, or we can quote DDP once we have confirmed we can act as importer of record in your country. Which do you prefer?"* That sentence has saved more margin than any negotiation technique.

1.3 Order entry: turning a purchase order into your contract

The moment a customer purchase order arrives, two documents are in play: theirs and yours. Their PO carries their standard terms — often including delivery penalties, retention, a governing law and a dispute forum you have never read. Your order confirmation, or the proforma invoice you ask them to sign, carries yours. Whichever one is last accepted without objection tends to govern.

This is why an order confirmation is not an acknowledgement. It is a counter-offer, and it must restate every commercial term in your own words rather than referring to theirs.

- ☐ Full legal names and addresses of both parties, exactly as they will appear on the customs and banking documents.
- ☐ Goods description that matches the HS code you intend to declare, and the description the letter of credit will use, if there is one.
- ☐ Quantity with tolerance (for example ± 5 per cent at seller's option) where the product is produced to weight or length.
- ☐ Unit price, total, currency, and the delivery term with a **named place** — "FCA" alone is not a delivery term, "FCA Gebze, Türkiye (Incoterms® 2020)" is.
- ☐ Payment terms in full: instrument, timing, and which party bears which bank charges.
- ☐ Lead time expressed from a defined trigger — from receipt of the signed proforma, or from receipt of the advance payment, or from receipt of a workable letter of credit. Never simply "30 days".
- ☐ Packing and marking specification, including pallet type and any heat-treatment (ISPM 15) requirement.
- ☐ Documents you will provide, listed, and documents the buyer must obtain themselves.
- ☐ Any inspection requirement, with the party who pays for it and the consequence of failure.
- ☐ Force majeure, governing law and dispute resolution.

WATCH OUT The lead-time trigger

A lead time that starts "on order" starts before you have money, before you have a workable credit, and often before the customer has finalised the specification. Experienced desks tie the clock to the last thing the *buyer* controls. If the buyer is late with the advance payment or the letter of credit, the delivery date moves with it, automatically and without an argument, because that is what the confirmation says.

1.4 The weekly rhythm

Export desks that run smoothly are not staffed by faster people. They are running a weekly cycle that has been stable long enough that every department knows what is expected of it and when. The shape below is common in Turkish manufacturers shipping containerised cargo to Europe and the Middle East; adjust the days, keep the structure.

Table 1.3 — A workable weekly cycle

Day	Export sales	Foreign trade / logistics
Monday	Confirm ready dates with planning; update customers whose dates moved	Collect carrier quotes; check equipment availability for the week
Tuesday	Issue and chase order confirmations; check L/C expiry and latest shipment dates	Place bookings against confirmed ready dates; register container pick-up
Wednesday	Prepare document sets for the week's shipments	Confirm inland transport; send loading programme to the factory
Thursday	Send draft documents to the customer or bank for pre-check	Follow loading; obtain VGM; submit customs declaration through the broker
Friday	Close the week: shipped list, pending list, and the exceptions that need Monday	Confirm gate-in against the cut-off; record any roll-over risk

The single most valuable habit in this table is the Thursday pre-check of documents against the letter of credit. It converts a rejected presentation into a corrected draft, at no cost.

CASE STUDY A missed cut-off that was visible on Tuesday

A machinery exporter in Konya confirmed a 40'HC to Antwerp for a Friday vessel. Production signalled on Monday that finishing would slip by a day. The desk noted it, told the customer, and did not tell logistics, because the ready date was still "this week".

The booking had a Wednesday 16:00 documentation cut-off and a Thursday 12:00 gate-in. The unit was ready Thursday afternoon. It missed gate-in by four hours, rolled to the next sailing seven days later, and the customer's installation crew — already booked — stood idle.

Nothing here was a logistics failure. The information existed on Monday and did not cross a departmental boundary. This is what the weekly cycle is for: **a ready date that moves is a logistics event, not a sales event**, and it is escalated the same day it is known.

1.5 Working with the other departments

1.5.1 Planning and production

Planning's constraint is capacity and changeover; yours is the promise date. The productive question is never "can you make it faster" but "what would have to move for this to ship on the fourteenth, and what does that cost us elsewhere". That question gets an answer because it respects the constraint. Bring the destination and the consequence with you: a unit for a plant shutdown window is genuinely different from stock replenishment, and planning cannot know that unless you say so.

1.5.2 Shipping and the customs broker

Your broker is not a document processor; they are the party who will be standing in front of customs when a line is red. Give them the file complete and early, tell them what is unusual about the shipment before they find it, and never let them learn about a value, an origin claim or a licence requirement from the paperwork alone. A broker who trusts your file will call you when something looks wrong; a broker who has been surprised twice will simply file what you sent.

1.5.3 Finance

Finance owns the money and, in Turkey, the export-proceeds obligations that attach to it. Bring them into the file at quotation, not at invoicing, whenever the payment term is anything other than an advance: a letter of credit with a confirmation requirement, a long credit period, or an unfamiliar currency all have costs that belong in the price.

1.6 Technical support for customer requirements

A large share of export enquiries are not commercial questions wearing a commercial costume; they are technical questions the customer cannot resolve locally. Specification confirmations, material certificates, tolerance queries, substitution requests, installation and spare-part questions — these arrive at the sales desk because it is the only address the customer has.

The desk's job is not to answer them. It is to route them fast and to translate in both directions, and the difference between a desk that does this well and one that does it badly is visible in the reorder rate.

- **Never answer a technical question from memory.** A confident wrong answer about a tolerance or a material grade becomes a claim, and the claim cites your e-mail.
- **Translate the question before forwarding it.** Engineering needs the application, not the customer's wording. "Can you supply grade X?" is usually "will this work at this temperature in this medium?" — and the second question gets a useful answer.
- **Give a date, not a promise.** "Engineering will answer by Thursday" is worth more to a customer than "soon", and it is a commitment you can keep.
- **Record the answer in the customer file.** The same question returns, from the same customer, in a different year, to a different colleague.
- **Watch for specification drift.** A customer who repeatedly asks whether a slightly different product would do is telling you their requirement has changed. That is a sales signal, and it is routinely missed.

FIELD NOTE Documents are technical support too

Material certificates, test reports, declarations of conformity and safety data sheets are requested late and needed urgently, because the customer's own customs or customer asked for them at the last moment. A desk that keeps the current version of each certificate for its top twenty products in one place answers in ten minutes. A desk that requests them from quality each time answers in two days, and occasionally after the vessel has sailed.

1.7 Post-shipment: the part juniors drop

The shipment leaving the gate feels like completion. It is roughly the midpoint. Four things still have to happen, and three of them have deadlines.

8. **Documents move.** Originals to the bank or courier to the buyer, on the day of shipment. Under a letter of credit, the presentation period runs from the shipment date and is typically 21 days unless the credit says otherwise — and it always also has to be within the credit's expiry.

- 9. Arrival is tracked.** Not because the customer cannot track it, but because you want to know about a delay before they do. A roll-over discovered by your customer is a different conversation from one you reported.
- 10. Receipt is confirmed and inspected.** Damage claims against a carrier have short notice windows; for road carriage under CMR, visible damage must be noted on delivery. If your customer signs clean and complains a week later, the claim is already difficult.
- 11. The file is closed.** The export declaration must be closed in the customs system and visible to the tax administration before a VAT refund can be claimed. This is covered in §2.8; it is mentioned here because the sales desk is usually the one holding the missing document.

FIELD NOTE Reading silence

Four silences mean trouble and should be chased rather than waited out.

- **A carrier that stops confirming.** A booking without a written confirmation of vessel and cut-off is not a booking.
- **A customer who goes quiet after receiving draft documents.** They are usually checking with their bank or their own customer, and the answer is often a change you would rather hear now.
- **A broker who does not confirm the declaration number.** The declaration may not have been lodged.
- **A bank that acknowledges a presentation but does not comment.** Under UCP 600 the issuing bank has a maximum of five banking days following presentation to examine and to give a single notice of refusal; silence approaching that limit is worth a call.

PRACTICAL EXERCISE Rebuild a quotation

Take a live enquiry from your desk and rebuild the quotation using the seven layers in §1.2.1. Write down every figure you had to guess or ask for. That list is your gap list — it is exactly the knowledge a five-year specialist carries without looking anything up, and it is short enough to close in a month.

CHAPTER 2

Foreign Trade and Logistics Operations

If export sales owns the promise, foreign trade owns the physics: a box of a particular size has to be at a particular gate before a particular hour, with a declaration lodged, a weight verified and a document set that a bank in another country will accept without comment.

This chapter is organised around the clock, because almost every operational failure in export logistics is a timing failure wearing a different costume.

By the end of this chapter you should be able to

- Turn a production plan into a loading programme that carriers can actually book against.
- Read a freight quotation and know which parts are negotiable and which are not.
- Manage cut-off, ETD and ETA as one chain rather than three separate facts.
- Prepare a letter of credit presentation that does not come back.
- Close an export file so that the VAT refund is not blocked six months later.

2.1 The loading programme

The loading programme is the single document that connects production output to booked transport capacity. Where it is missing, its absence is filled by phone calls, and phone calls do not survive an audit or a Monday morning.

A workable programme is built backwards from the vessel or the truck, not forwards from the factory. Take the sailing you intend to catch, subtract the documentation cut-off, subtract the gate-in deadline, subtract the inland transit, subtract the loading and lashing time, and you have the hour at which the goods must be finished, packed and weighed. That hour — not the vessel date — is what production needs from you.

Table 2.1 — Working backwards from a Friday sailing (typical container export, Marmara to North Europe)

Milestone	Timing	Owner	Failure consequence
Vessel ETD	Friday	Carrier	—
Port gate-in (container in terminal)	Thursday, typically 24–48 h before ETD	Inland carrier	Roll-over to next sailing
Documentation cut-off (shipping instructions, VGM)	Wednesday, often earlier than gate-in	Foreign trade	No bill of lading on the intended vessel
Customs declaration lodged and closed	Wednesday	Broker	Container cannot enter the terminal
Container loaded and sealed at the factory	Tuesday–Wednesday	Shipping / factory	Inland transit compressed, overtime cost
Container collected from the depot	Tuesday	Inland carrier	Empty not available; loading date slips
Goods finished, packed, weighed, marked	Monday–Tuesday	Production	Everything downstream moves

Transit times and cut-offs vary by port, carrier and season. Build this table once for each lane you use regularly and keep it current; it is the most useful single page on a foreign trade desk.

WATCH OUT Documentation cut-off is usually earlier than gate-in

Juniors plan to the gate-in because it is physical and easy to picture. Carriers, however, close the documentation window first — shipping instructions and verified gross mass have to be in the system before the manifest is built. A container that is physically inside the terminal but missing its VGM does not sail. Track both deadlines separately on every booking.

2.2 Freight: how the number is built

A freight quotation looks like one price and is in fact a stack of separate charges with different owners, different volatility and very different negotiability. Reading the stack is what allows you to argue about the right line.

Table 2.2 — Anatomy of an ocean freight quotation

Component	What it is	How negotiable
Ocean freight (base)	Port-to-port carriage for the equipment type	Negotiable, and the main lever on volume lanes
BAF / bunker or low-	Fuel cost pass-through	Rarely negotiable line by

Component	What it is	How negotiable
sulphur surcharge		line; negotiate the all-in instead
THC origin and destination	Terminal handling at each end	Tariffed by the terminal; who <i>pays</i> it is negotiable, the amount usually is not
Documentation / bill of lading fee	Issuing the transport document	Small, but check for duplicates when a forwarder is in the chain
Seal, VGM, ISPS, congestion, peak season	Fixed and situational surcharges	Ask for them to be listed at quotation, not added at invoice
Inland haulage (merchant or carrier haulage)	Factory to port	Compare both: carrier haulage is simpler, merchant haulage is often cheaper and always more controllable
Free time (demurrage / detention)	Days allowed before penalties start	The most under-negotiated line on the sheet

Demurrage runs on the container inside the terminal; detention runs on the container outside it. Confusing them is a common and expensive error.

FIELD NOTE Negotiate free time before you negotiate rate

On a lane where your customer is slow to clear, five extra free days at destination are worth more than a rate reduction, and they cost the carrier less to give. A forwarder who will not move on rate will very often move on free time, because it does not touch their published tariff.

Always ask for the free-time figure **in writing on the booking confirmation**. "Standard free time" means whatever the destination agent decides when the invoice is issued.

2.2.1 Equipment: choosing the box

Equipment choice is a volume-versus-weight decision, and the constraint is almost never the container. It is the road: axle and gross-weight limits on the inland leg routinely bind before the container's own payload does, and the limit that matters is the one in the country where the truck drives.

Table 2.3 — Standard equipment, indicative figures

Type	Internal capacity (approx.)	Typical use
20'DC	about 33 m ³	Dense cargo: stone, machinery, chemicals in drums. Volume is rarely the limit; weight is.
40'DC	about 67 m ³	General cargo where weight per m ³ is moderate.
40'HC	about 76 m ³	The default for light, bulky cargo — extra height, same footprint.
45'HC	about 86 m ³	Where the carrier and the road permit it; check inland legality before quoting.
Reefer	Reduced by insulation and machinery	Temperature-controlled; requires set-point, ventilation and pre-trip inspection on the booking.
Open top /	Out-of-gauge	Requires dimensions, weight distribution and, usually, an

Type	Internal capacity (approx.)	Typical use
flat rack		out-of-gauge surcharge quoted in advance.

Capacities and payloads differ by owner and container age. Confirm the payload of the specific unit with the carrier before you plan a heavy load; never plan to a table.

CASE STUDY The 20' that could not leave the yard

A marble exporter loaded 26 tonnes into a 20'DC — comfortably inside the container's payload and comfortably outside the road weight limit for the tractor-trailer combination taking it to the port. The unit was refused at the weighbridge, returned to the factory, stripped, and split across two boxes. The cost was two days, one missed sailing and a second set of handling charges.

The lesson is not about marble. It is that **the container payload and the legal road weight are two different limits, and the smaller one governs**. Ask for the road limit on the specific route, in writing, before you plan a heavy load.

2.3 Inland transport and port organisation

Under merchant haulage you control the inland leg and therefore own its failures. That is usually the right trade: you can choose the depot, sequence the collection and speak to the driver. Three habits separate a controlled inland leg from a hopeful one.

12.Book the empty against the loading slot, not the sailing. Depots run out of the specific type you need, and a 40'HC promised on Tuesday is not a 40'HC standing in your yard on Tuesday.

13.Inspect the empty before loading. Holes, previous cargo residue, a floor that fails a light test, a missing CSC plate — all are yours to reject at the gate and impossible to argue after loading. Photograph the interior and the container number.

14.Seal, photograph, record. The seal number goes on the packing list, the bill of lading instruction and the declaration. A seal number that does not match across the three is a documentary discrepancy and, at destination, a customs question.

FIELD NOTE Verified gross mass, and who is liable

Since the 2016 amendment to SOLAS chapter VI, a packed container may not be loaded on a ship without a verified gross mass declared by the shipper. Two methods are permitted: weighing the packed container, or weighing the cargo and adding the certified tare. The obligation sits with the party named as shipper on the bill of lading — which, in an FCA or FOB sale, is very often you rather than your buyer. Confirm who is submitting the VGM at booking, every time.

2.4 The clock: cut-off, ETD, ETA and roll-over

These four words describe one chain, and treating them as separate facts is what produces the characteristic junior surprise: a shipment that was "on track" until the day it was not.

- **Cut-off** is a set of deadlines, not one: documentation cut-off, VGM cut-off, gate-in cut-off, and sometimes a separate cut-off for hazardous or reefer cargo. Record all of them on the booking.
- **ETD** is an estimate that carriers revise. A vessel that slips by a day at origin does not usually recover it, and a slip announced late in the week is often a sign that the vessel is already full.
- **ETA** is an estimate compounded by transshipment. On a routing with one transshipment, ask which leg is the constraint; the connection, not the ocean, is where time is lost.
- **Roll-over** is the carrier moving your container to a later sailing, usually because the vessel is overbooked. It is not a breach of anything. Your protection is early gate-in, a named booking

reference confirmed in writing, and — on critical shipments — a written request for loading confirmation once the vessel has sailed.

WATCH OUT Tell the customer before the system does

Modern buyers track containers themselves. A roll-over your customer discovers on a tracking portal costs you credibility that a roll-over you report does not. The rule on an experienced desk is simple: **any date change reaches the customer the same working day it reaches you**, with the new date and the recovery plan in the same message.

2.5 Customs: the declaration and the line

In Türkiye the export declaration (*gümrük çıkış beyannamesi*) is lodged electronically by the customs broker acting under your authority. Once lodged, the system assigns an inspection line, and the line determines how long the shipment takes and what can still go wrong.

Table 2.4 — Inspection lines and what they mean on the day

Line	What happens	What the desk should do
Green (<i>yeşil</i>)	No documentary or physical check; the declaration proceeds	Nothing — but keep the file complete; post-clearance audit still applies
Yellow (<i>sarı</i>)	Documentary check by the customs officer	Have the invoice, packing list, licences and any origin document immediately available in the exact form declared
Red (<i>kırmızı</i>)	Documentary and physical examination of the goods	Expect a day; make sure someone can attend, and that the goods are physically accessible and marked as declared
Blue (<i>mavi</i>)	Cleared now, examined afterwards under post-clearance control	Archive the complete file; this is the line where a weak file surfaces months later

Line assignment is risk-based and not disclosed in advance. Consistency between what you declare and what you ship is the only thing you control — and it is what the risk system measures.

Three declaration fields cause most of the trouble, and all three are decided by the export sales desk long before the broker sees the file: **the commodity code**, **the declared value**, and **the origin claim**. Chapter 3 treats each as a document problem; here it is enough to say that the broker cannot verify any of them for you. They file what you assert.

FIELD NOTE Authorised operator status changes the calculus

Türkiye operates an authorised operator regime — *Yetkilendirilmiş Yükümlü Sertifikası* (YYYS), the Turkish AEO — which brings simplified procedures, fewer physical examinations and, in particular, the ability to complete formalities at the exporter's own premises. If your company ships regular volume and does not hold it, the business case is usually strong and the application is largely an exercise in documenting the processes this chapter describes. Confirm the current requirements with the Ministry of Trade before building a case.

2.6 Payment operations: letters of credit and documents against payment

Two instruments dominate Turkish export practice outside open account: the documentary credit (letter of credit) and documentary collection, usually cash against documents. They protect you to very different degrees, and they fail in very different ways.

2.6.1 The documentary credit

A credit is a bank's undertaking to pay against **documents that comply with the credit** — not against goods, and not against performance. This single sentence, from UCP 600, explains every behaviour that frustrates newcomers: banks deal in documents alone, and a perfect shipment documented imperfectly does not get paid on time.

- 15. Check the credit the day it arrives, not the week you ship.** Read it as a list of things you must produce. Anything you cannot produce is an amendment request, and amendments take days you will not have later.
- 16. Check the dates as a set:** latest shipment date, presentation period, and expiry. A credit expiring at the counters of the issuing bank abroad means your documents must arrive there before expiry, not leave Türkiye before it.
- 17. Check the description of goods.** It must be reproduced on the commercial invoice; other documents may describe the goods in general terms, but they must not contradict.
- 18. Check who issues each document and what it must state.** "Certificate of origin issued by the Chamber of Commerce" and "certificate of origin" are different requirements.
- 19. Present early.** A presentation made with days to spare can be corrected once; a presentation made on the last day cannot.

Table 2.5 — Discrepancies most often cited on Turkish presentations

Discrepancy	Why it happens	Prevention
Late presentation	Documents assembled after shipment rather than before	Build the set from the credit before the goods are ready
Credit expired	Expiry read as a shipment deadline	Diarise expiry, latest shipment and presentation period separately
Goods description differs from the credit	Invoice copied from the sales order	Copy the description from the credit, character for character
Documents inconsistent with each other	Weight, marks or seal number retyped per document	Generate all documents from one data set; never retype
Bill of lading not marked as required	"Clean on board", freight prepaid, notify party omitted	Send the draft B/L to the carrier with the credit's wording quoted
Insurance below the required percentage or wrong currency	Policy issued to standard terms	Instruct the insurer with the credit text, typically 110 per cent of CIF value in the credit currency
Missing signature, stamp or legalisation	Requirement buried in the credit's additional conditions	Read the additional conditions field last and again

Under UCP 600 the issuing bank has a maximum of five banking days following the day of presentation to determine compliance, and any refusal must be given in a single notice stating each discrepancy.

2.6.2 Documents against payment

In a documentary collection the banks act as couriers with instructions, not as guarantors. Your protection is control of the transport document: with a negotiable bill of lading consigned to order, the buyer cannot take delivery without the originals the bank holds. That protection evaporates on a straight consigned air waybill or a road consignment note, where the named consignee can collect the goods without any document from you at all.

WATCH OUT CAD by truck to a nearby market is weaker than it looks

A CMR consignment note is not a document of title. If you ship on CAD terms by road, consigned directly to the buyer, the goods will be delivered on arrival whether or not the buyer has paid the

collecting bank. Where you cannot ship to order, either take an advance payment or accept that you are, in substance, on open account and price accordingly.

2.7 Closing the file

An export is not finished when the goods arrive. In Türkiye it is finished when the declaration is closed, the proceeds are handled as the regulations require, and the VAT position is settled. This is where the foreign trade desk earns its keep quietly, and where neglected files turn into blocked refunds months later.

20. Confirm the declaration is closed. The customs system records the exit of the goods; the closed declaration is what the tax administration will look for. An open declaration is the single most common cause of a stalled refund.

21. Collect and archive the closed declaration and the transport document with the invoice and the exporters' association registration. Archive retention periods are set by customs and tax legislation; keep the file whole rather than scattered across departments.

22. Handle the proceeds according to the current export circular. Türkiye has, since 2018, operated an obligation to repatriate export proceeds within a set period, with a share to be sold to the Central Bank. Both the period and the percentage have changed repeatedly. Never work from memory here — check the current *İhracat Genelgesi* with finance for each period.

23. Submit the VAT refund file. Exports are exempt with credit, so input VAT is recoverable. Depending on the amount and the method chosen, refunds may require a certified public accountant's report or a guarantee. Finance owns the submission; you own the completeness of the underlying documents.

WATCH OUT Three things that block a refund months later

- A declaration that was never closed because the goods left under a different declaration number after a re-loading.
- An invoice whose value or quantity does not match the closed declaration after a post-shipment credit note.
- A missing exporters' association registration on a declaration that was lodged in a hurry.

All three are cheap to fix in the week they happen and expensive to reconstruct in the quarter they surface.

2.8 Monthly reporting

A monthly operations report exists to change decisions. If it does not change a carrier allocation, a lane, a term or a customer conversation, it is a ritual. Five measures are enough for most manufacturers.

Table 2.6 — A five-measure operations report

Measure	Definition	The decision it should drive
Shipped tonnage and volume	By lane and by equipment type	Where to seek a contract rate rather than spot
Freight cost per tonne and per unit	All-in, including surcharges and inland	Whether the delivery term you quote still makes sense
On-time gate-in	Containers gated in before cut-off, as a share of bookings	Which internal step is causing roll-overs

Measure	Definition	The decision it should drive
Carrier reliability	Sailed as booked, without roll-over, by carrier	Allocation for the next quarter
Documentary rejection rate	Presentations returned by banks, with reason	Which document to redesign, and who to retrain

Report the rejection rate by reason, not as a total. A single recurring reason is a process fix; a scatter of one-off reasons is a training issue.

PRACTICAL EXERCISE Build your lane sheet

Pick the lane you ship most often. On one page, record: the carriers you use, the documentation and gate-in cut-offs, the transit time, the free time at both ends, the inland transit, and the last three roll-overs with their causes. Keep it current for one quarter.

That page will answer more daily questions than any system you have access to, and it is the artefact that most clearly distinguishes an experienced desk from a busy one.

CHAPTER 3

Documentation Master Guide

Every export document answers one question and is rejected for one of three reasons: the wrong party issued it, it does not say what the reader needs it to say, or it contradicts another document in the same set.

This chapter treats documents as instruments rather than forms. For each one: what it proves, who may issue it, what it must contain, and the specific way it fails.

By the end of this chapter you should be able to

- Say what any document in a standard export set actually proves, and to whom.
- Distinguish a document of title from a receipt — and price the difference.
- Choose correctly between a certificate of origin, an A.TR and a EUR.1.
- Build a document set from one data source so that it cannot contradict itself.

3.1 How to think about a document set

A document set has three readers, and they want different things. **Customs** wants to know what the goods are, what they are worth and where they came from. **The carrier** wants to know what it received and from whom. **The bank** wants to know whether the papers match the credit.

Almost every documentary failure is a failure to serve one of those three readers while serving another. An invoice written for the bank in the credit's exact wording may describe goods in terms customs finds vague; a description written for the tariff may not match the credit. The professional habit is to decide, per shipment, which reader is the binding constraint — and it is the bank whenever a documentary credit is involved, because that reader can withhold money.

DEFINITION The consistency rule

Under UCP 600, data in a document must not conflict with data in that document, with any other stipulated document, or with the credit. Note what this does **not** say: documents need not be identical. A bill of lading may describe goods in general terms, provided the description does not contradict the credit. Only the commercial invoice must reproduce the credit's description of the goods.

The practical consequence is that the fields which must match exactly across the set are the countable ones — quantities, weights, marks, numbers, seal and container numbers, dates — and these are exactly the fields that get retyped.

3.2 The commercial set

3.2.1 Proforma invoice

A proforma invoice is an offer, not an accounting document. Its function is to be signed. Once countersigned by the buyer it is the cleanest evidence of the agreed terms, and in many markets it is also what the buyer's bank needs in order to open a credit and what the buyer's customs needs for an import licence.

- ☐ Marked clearly as *Proforma Invoice*, with a number and date.
- ☐ Seller and buyer legal names and addresses as they will appear on every downstream document.
- ☐ Goods description, HS code, quantity, unit price, total, currency.
- ☐ Delivery term with named place and the Incoterms edition.
- ☐ Payment terms in full, including the bank details you will actually use.
- ☐ Validity, lead time with its trigger, packing and country of origin.
- ☐ A signature block for the buyer.

3.2.2 Commercial invoice

The commercial invoice is the value document: it drives customs valuation at both ends, the accounting entry, and the bank's examination. In Türkiye it is issued electronically — exports are invoiced through the e-invoice system under the export scenario, and the electronic invoice is matched to the customs declaration. Practically, that means the invoice exists in a government system before it exists in your document set, and correcting it after the fact is a formal process, not an edit.

WATCH OUT What must never be quietly adjusted

Buyers occasionally ask for an invoice value lower than the contract price — to reduce import duty — or for a description that fits a lower tariff line. This is not a favour with a small risk; it is a false declaration in both countries, it invalidates your insurance, it breaks the match between the invoice and the closed declaration that your VAT refund depends on, and it exposes named individuals. The correct answer is

no, and the correct escalation is to your manager and, in writing, to the customer.

3.2.3 Packing list

The packing list is the reconciliation document: it is what a customs officer at a red line, or a surveyor after damage, uses to check what is physically present against what was declared. It earns its place only if it is granular — package by package, with marks, dimensions, net and gross weight — and if it carries the same container and seal numbers as the transport document.

3.3 Transport documents

The single most consequential distinction in export documentation: some transport documents control delivery of the goods, and some merely record it.

Table 3.1 — Transport documents and what they give you

Document	Mode	Document of title?	What this means in practice
Bill of lading (negotiable, to order)	Sea	Yes	Goods are released against surrender of an original. This is what makes CAD and letters of credit work.
Straight (consigned) bill of lading	Sea	No, in substance	Named consignee takes delivery on identification. Little payment protection.
Sea waybill	Sea	No	Fast and paperless; use only on open account or against advance payment.
Air waybill (AWB)	Air	No	Consigned to a named party. To retain control, consign to the bank with its written agreement, never without it.
CMR consignment note	Road	No	A receipt and a contract of carriage. Delivery is to the named consignee.
TIR carnet	Road (transit)	No	A customs transit and guarantee instrument, not a commercial document.
CIM consignment note	Rail	No	As CMR, for rail carriage.
Multimodal / FIATA FBL	Multimodal	Can be, if negotiable	Check the form: a FIATA negotiable FBL is a title document; a forwarder's certificate of receipt is not.

Rule of thumb: if the payment term relies on the buyer needing a piece of paper from you, verify that the transport document is genuinely negotiable before you ship.

FIELD NOTE Reading a bill of lading the way a bank does

- **Clean.** No clause declaring a defective condition of goods or packaging. A remark about the condition of the packaging is what makes a bill "claused", and a claused bill under a credit is a discrepancy.
- **On board.** A received-for-shipment bill needs an on-board notation with a date; that date is the shipment date.
- **Consignee and notify party.** Exactly as the credit says. "To order of [issuing bank]" and "to order" are different.
- **Freight prepaid or collect.** Must match the delivery term. A CFR shipment with a "freight collect" bill is an immediate discrepancy.

- **Number of originals issued.** Usually three; the credit will say how many must be presented. Surrendering one original releases the goods, so never send a full set unsecured.

3.4 Origin, preference and free circulation

This section causes more expensive errors than any other in Turkish export documentation, because three quite different documents are all loosely called "the origin paper".

Table 3.2 — Three documents that are not interchangeable

Document	What it actually certifies	Where it is used	Issued / endorsed by
Certificate of origin (<i>Menşe Şahadetnamesi</i>)	The country in which the goods were produced	Non-preferential purposes: import formalities, tenders, letters of credit, some sanctions and quota regimes	Chamber of commerce
A.TR movement certificate	Free circulation status in the EU–Türkiye Customs Union — not origin	Industrial goods moving between Türkiye and the EU	Chamber, endorsed by customs
EUR.1 / origin declaration	Preferential origin under a specific free trade agreement	Türkiye's FTA partners, and EU trade in goods outside the Customs Union's scope	Chamber, endorsed by customs; or the exporter, where approved

Verify current coverage and procedure with the Ministry of Trade and your chamber before relying on this table for a specific shipment.

WATCH OUT The A.TR trap

An A.TR lets goods enter the EU without customs duty because they are in free circulation in the Customs Union. It says nothing about where they were made. Two consequences follow, and both have cost Turkish exporters money.

- An A.TR does **not** exempt goods from trade defence measures — anti-dumping and countervailing duties are applied by origin. Goods of third-country origin, in free circulation in Türkiye, can arrive in the EU duty-free under A.TR and still attract an anti-dumping duty on their true origin.
- An A.TR is **not** acceptable as proof of origin where a buyer or a third country asks for origin — for a tender, for onward preferential claims, or for sanctions screening. That requires a certificate of origin or, for preference, a EUR.1.

When a customer asks for "the origin document", ask what they need it for. The answer changes which document you issue.

Preferential origin is earned, not asserted. Every free trade agreement contains origin rules — wholly obtained, sufficient transformation, a change of tariff heading, a maximum share of non-originating value — and a claim you cannot support with production records is a claim that will be withdrawn on verification, retroactively, with duty payable by your customer. Keep the supplier declarations and the bill of materials that support each claim, for as long as the agreement requires.

3.5 Insurance

Only two Incoterms rules oblige the seller to insure: CIF and CIP. Everywhere else, insurance is a commercial decision about your own exposure between the point where risk passes and the point where you are paid — which are rarely the same point.

- **CIF** requires cover complying at minimum with Institute Cargo Clauses (C) — a restricted, named-perils cover.
- **CIP** requires, since the 2020 revision, cover complying at minimum with Institute Cargo Clauses (A) — an all-risks cover.
- Under a documentary credit, insurance is typically required for 110 per cent of the CIF or CIP value, in the currency of the credit, and must be issued no later than the shipment date.
- An insurance **certificate** issued under an open policy is normally acceptable; a broker's cover note usually is not.

FIELD NOTE Insure to the point of payment, not the point of risk transfer

On an FCA sale with sixty-day open-account terms, your risk in the goods ends at the carrier's vehicle but your exposure to the transaction ends only when the money arrives. If the cargo is lost in transit and the buyer's own insurance disputes the claim, you may find yourself negotiating with a customer who has no goods and no enthusiasm for paying. Contingent or seller's-interest cover exists for exactly this gap and is inexpensive.

3.6 Regulatory, product and special documents

Table 3.3 — Situational documents and their triggers

Document	Triggered by	Watch for
Phytosanitary certificate	Plants, plant products, and often wood packaging	Issued by the agriculture authority; inspection must precede loading, not follow it
Health / veterinary certificate	Food of animal origin	Destination-specific wording; establishment must be listed by the importing country
ISPM 15 marking	Solid wood packaging and dunnage	Marking on the wood itself; a certificate does not replace the stamp
Certificate of analysis / conformity	Chemicals, food, technical products	Must be issued by the party the contract or credit names
Pre-shipment inspection certificate	Buyer, destination regime or credit	Book the inspection against the loading date; a missed inspection cannot be recovered after sealing
Dangerous goods declaration	Classified hazardous cargo	Correct UN number, packing group and IMDG segregation; booking must be made as hazardous from the start
ATA carnet	Temporary export: samples, exhibitions, professional equipment	Goods must return in the same state and within validity, or duty becomes payable
Legalisation / consular attestation	Several Middle Eastern and North African markets	Chamber attestation, then consulate; allow days, and check whether electronic attestation is accepted

3.7 The consistency matrix

The single most effective documentary control is not a checklist of documents but a matrix of **fields** — the countable values that must agree wherever they appear. Build it once, per shipment, from one source, and check the finished set against it before anything leaves the office.

Table 3.4 — Fields that must agree across the set

Field	Invoice	Packing list	Transport doc	Origin doc	Credit
Seller / beneficiary name	•	•	•	•	•
Buyer / consignee name	•	•	•	•	•
Goods description	exact	general	general	general	source
Quantity and unit	•	•	•	•	•
Net and gross weight	•	•	•		
Marks and numbers	•	•	•		
Container and seal number	•	•	•		
Delivery term and named place	•				•
Country of origin	•			•	•
Invoice number and date	•	•	often	•	

"Exact" means reproduced from the credit word for word; "general" means consistent but not necessarily identical; "source" means the credit is the origin of the wording.

PRACTICAL EXERCISE Audit your last presentation

Take the last document set your company presented under a credit. Fill in Table 3.4 from the actual documents and mark every cell where two documents disagree, however trivially. Then check those cells against the discrepancies the bank raised, if any.

On most desks this exercise finds two or three latent disagreements that were not raised — that time. Those are the discrepancies waiting for a stricter examiner.

CHAPTER 4

Country Compliance Desk

A Turkish exporter operates under one body of law and is reached by several others. Turkish rules bind you directly and are enforced against you. Foreign rules reach you through your buyer, your bank and your contract — and they are enforced by losing the shipment, the payment or the customer.

This chapter is a desk reference for the six jurisdictions that dominate Turkish export practice. It is deliberately structured the same way for each: what governs, what it means for your documents, and what most often goes wrong.

By the end of this chapter you should be able to

- Identify, for any destination, which requirements are yours and which are your buyer's.
- Run a screening routine before quoting, not after shipping.
- Recognise the recurring compliance traps in EU, UK, US, Russian and Chinese trade.
- Know when to stop a transaction and how to record that decision.

4.1 Using this chapter

Everything below is a map, not a legal text. Tariff lines, listings and thresholds change on a timescale of weeks, and a guide that pretended otherwise would be dangerous rather than useful.

Each section names the primary source you must open before you rely on anything. The discipline that separates a professional from an enthusiastic amateur is not knowing the rule from memory — it is knowing which source is authoritative and checking it at the moment of commitment. Quote the source in your internal file note; when the rule changes six months later, your file will show that the decision was reasonable when it was made.

WATCH OUT Where this guide stops

This chapter explains how to establish that a transaction is lawful, how to document that determination, and when to decline. It does not explain how to move restricted goods, how to route payments around a control, or how to structure a sale so that a prohibition does not appear to apply. Those are not grey areas that experienced operators quietly navigate; they are the conduct that ends companies, removes correspondent banking relationships and creates personal liability for the people who signed.

If your analysis reaches "this is prohibited unless we present it differently", the analysis is finished and the answer is no. Escalate it in writing.

4.2 Türkiye — the baseline that binds you

Turkish export law is the only body of rules in this chapter that can be enforced against you directly and routinely. The framework rests on the Customs Law and the export regime instruments issued under it, administered through the customs administration and, for most exporters, experienced day to day through the exporters' associations and the single window.

Table 4.1 — Turkish framework: what each instrument does to your desk

Instrument	What it governs	Where it touches your work
Customs Law No. 4458 and its implementing regulation	Declarations, procedures, transit, penalties, post-clearance control	Every declaration; the record retention you will need years later
Export Regime Decree and Export Regulation	Which goods may be exported, and under what registration or licence	Goods subject to registration or authorisation; prohibited and restricted lists
Exporters' associations regime	Registration of the declaration and the associations' contribution	A declaration lodged without registration is a refund problem later
e-invoicing rules	Electronic issue of the export invoice and its match to the declaration	The invoice is created in a state system before it enters your set
Single Window System	Electronic submission of permits and certificates	Licences and certificates flow to customs electronically; paper is the exception
Inward Processing Regime	Relief on imported inputs used in exported goods	Only if the authorisation is in place <i>before</i> the inputs arrive
Export proceeds circular	Repatriation of proceeds and sale of a share to the Central Bank	Percentage and period have changed repeatedly — verify each period
VAT legislation	Export exemption with credit, and refund procedure	The closed declaration is the key that unlocks the refund

Primary sources: Ministry of Trade (Ticaret Bakanlığı) and the Revenue Administration (Gelir İdaresi Başkanlığı). Check the current text before relying on any line in this table.

FIELD NOTE Inward processing is decided before the input is bought

The Inward Processing Regime lets you bring in inputs without paying duty and VAT, provided the finished goods are exported within the authorisation period. It is one of the largest competitiveness levers available to a Turkish manufacturer — and it is unavailable retroactively. Purchasing imports the material, but it is the export desk that knows the material is destined for an export order. If that information does not move at purchase-order time, the relief is lost for that batch.

4.3 European Union — the Customs Union and everything it does not cover

The EU–Türkiye Customs Union removes customs duty on industrial goods in free circulation, evidenced by an A.TR movement certificate. Junior desks read this as "no barriers to the EU". Experienced desks read it as "no *duty* on *industrial* goods, and every other kind of requirement still applies".

- **Scope.** The Customs Union covers industrial products and processed agricultural goods; primary agricultural products and, historically, coal and steel are handled under separate arrangements. Confirm the treatment of your specific tariff line rather than your sector.
- **A.TR is free circulation, not origin.** Trade defence duties — anti-dumping, countervailing — are applied by origin regardless of the A.TR. See the trap in §3.4.
- **Product compliance is a separate universe from customs.** CE marking, harmonised standards, REACH, RoHS and sector regulations apply to the product, not to the shipment, and non-compliance surfaces at market surveillance rather than at the border.
- **REACH obligations fall on the EU-based importer or on an Only Representative appointed by you.** A Turkish manufacturer exporting substances or mixtures cannot register directly; the practical choice is to let the importer register or to appoint an Only Representative, which keeps the registration under your control if you change distributors.
- **General product safety.** For consumer products, the EU requires a responsible economic operator established in the Union whose details appear on the product or packaging. A distributor arrangement that leaves nobody named is a market-access failure, not a paperwork one.
- **Carbon border adjustment.** CBAM covers goods including iron and steel, aluminium, cement, fertilisers, hydrogen and electricity. Reporting obligations fall on the EU importer, but the emissions data can only come from you. Exporters in covered sectors should be able to produce installation-level embedded-emissions data on request; those who cannot will lose orders to those who can. Verify current scope, thresholds and timing — this regime is still moving.

CASE STUDY Duty-free and still dutiable

A Turkish trading company bought steel fasteners of far-eastern origin, held them in free circulation in Türkiye, and sold them to a German distributor under an A.TR. No customs duty was charged on entry, exactly as expected.

Eleven months later the German importer received a post-clearance demand: the goods were subject to an EU anti-dumping duty applied by **origin**, and the A.TR had never displaced it. The importer paid, then turned to the contract. The Turkish seller had described the goods as "Turkish origin" on the invoice because they had been shipped from Türkiye.

The commercial loss was the customer. The lesson is narrow and worth memorising: **an A.TR answers a duty question, a certificate of origin answers an origin question, and only the second protects you against a trade defence measure.**

4.4 United Kingdom — a customs border, and a different set of marks

Since the end of the transition period the United Kingdom is outside the EU customs territory, and therefore outside the EU–Türkiye Customs Union. The A.TR has no application to the UK. Trade runs instead on the bilateral free trade agreement in force since the beginning of 2021, which means **preference must be claimed on origin** rather than assumed on free circulation.

- **Origin proof.** A EUR.1 movement certificate, or an origin declaration on the invoice where you qualify as an approved exporter. The origin rules of the agreement — not the fact of shipping from Türkiye — determine whether the claim is valid.
- **Cumulation and verification.** Claims are subject to verification requests years after the event. Keep supplier declarations and production records for the period the agreement specifies.
- **Customs formalities.** UK import declarations are made by the UK importer through the customs declaration service; your obligations are documentary. Confirm who holds the GB EORI and who is importer of record before quoting a delivered term.
- **Product marking.** The UKCA mark is the UK conformity route, but recognition of CE marking has been extended for a large share of goods. Whether your product may still be placed on the GB market under CE depends on the product area — verify per product, and note that Northern Ireland follows different rules again.
- **Sanitary and phytosanitary controls** on food, plants and animal products have been introduced in phases with changing documentary and inspection requirements. For these goods, check the current UK import model rather than relying on last year's experience.

4.5 United States — your buyer imports, your compliance still travels

In a sale to a US buyer the importer of record is normally the buyer, and the entry, tariff classification and duty are theirs. This leads to a common misreading — that US rules are not your problem. Three of them are.

Table 4.2 — What actually reaches a Turkish seller from the US side

Requirement	Whose obligation	Why it reaches you
Importer Security Filing (ISF, "10+2")	US importer / carrier	The data comes from you, and it is due before the container is loaded in Türkiye. Late data means the box does not sail.
CBP entry and HTSUS classification	US importer	Your invoice description and HS code drive it; a mismatch delays clearance and invites a valuation question
Section 232 / Section 301 duties	US importer pays	Steel and aluminium measures have applied to Turkish goods at varying rates. Confirm the current rate before quoting DDP or agreeing to bear duty.
FDA, USDA, FCC, CPSC requirements	US importer, but product-based	Prior notice for food, facility registration, labelling — all of which depend on documents only you can issue
OFAC sanctions	US persons; and anyone using USD clearing	Your bank screens the transaction. A counterparty or vessel on a list stops the payment, not just the shipment.
Forced labour import ban (UFLPA)	US importer, on a rebuttable presumption	If your inputs include material from the affected region, the burden of tracing falls back to you through the contract

*AES / Electronic Export Information filing is an obligation on exports **from** the United States. For a Turkish exporter it becomes relevant only on returns, replacements or re-exports out of the US.*

FIELD NOTE Supply-chain tracing is now a sales requirement

US and EU forced-labour and due-diligence rules have made the origin of *inputs* a commercial question, not only a regulatory one. Buyers increasingly ask for a bill of materials with supplier countries before they place an order. An exporter who can answer in a day wins orders from one who needs a month. Build the input-origin record while the order is being quoted, not when the buyer asks.

4.6 Russia — compliance-first, and the discipline of stopping

Russia remains a significant market for Turkish exporters, and it is the destination where an operations desk is most likely to be asked to do something it should refuse. Türkiye does not apply EU or US sanctions as a matter of Turkish law. That fact is frequently misread as meaning the measures are irrelevant to a Turkish company. They are not, for three practical reasons.

- 24. Your banks apply them.** Turkish banks with correspondent relationships in dollars and euros screen against US, EU and UK lists and will refuse or freeze payments. A contract you may lawfully sign is worth nothing if no bank will settle it.
- 25. Your suppliers pass them down.** EU-origin goods are increasingly sold under contractual clauses prohibiting re-export to Russia, with audit and termination rights attached. Breaching such a clause loses the supplier, and in serious cases the supply chain.
- 26. Anti-circumvention measures target intermediaries.** Both the EU and the US have listed companies in third countries, including Türkiye, for facilitating restricted flows. Listing is commercially terminal: banks, insurers and freight forwarders withdraw.
 - **Screen every party, every time** — buyer, consignee, notify party, end user, the vessel and the bank. Listings change constantly and a customer cleared last quarter is not cleared today.
 - **Classify the goods against dual-use and restricted lists**, including the common high-priority items lists that the EU, US and partners publish for anti-circumvention. If your product appears on one, expect scrutiny even where the sale is lawful.
 - **Establish and record the end use and end user.** An end-user statement is evidence of diligence, not a substitute for it; treat inconsistent, evasive or unusually urgent answers as a stop signal.
 - **Expect market-entry requirements to be technical, not just commercial.** Goods placed on the Eurasian Economic Union market generally require conformity to EAEU technical regulations and, where applicable, the EAC mark, with certification through an accredited body. This is separate from anything sanctions-related.
 - **The customs declarant in Russia is normally a Russian person**, which constrains delivered terms in the same way discussed in §1.2.2.

WATCH OUT Red flags that should stop a Russian-market order at the desk

- A new buyer, incorporated recently, ordering goods unrelated to any visible business activity.
- A request to route goods through a third country with no commercial logic, or to name a different consignee from the end user.
- A willingness to pay a premium well above market, or an insistence on unusual payment channels.
- Refusal to provide end-use information, or an end-use statement that does not match the technical specification ordered.
- A request to describe the goods on documents in terms that do not match what is being shipped.

One of these is a question. Two together is an escalation to compliance, in writing, before you quote.

4.7 China — classification, registration and inspection

Türkiye and China trade on most-favoured-nation terms; there is no free trade agreement between them, so there is no preferential origin claim to make and no EUR.1 to issue. The friction in China-bound shipments is not tariff preference but **admissibility**: classification, product registration and inspection.

- **Classification.** China's tariff uses codes extending beyond the six-digit international level. A code that is correct in Türkiye can map to more than one Chinese line with different duty, inspection and licensing consequences. Ask your buyer for the Chinese code they will declare and reconcile it with yours before shipment.
- **Registration for food and agricultural products.** Chinese customs requires overseas producers of many food categories to be registered before their goods may be imported, with registration numbers appearing on labels and documents. Registration is the manufacturer's obligation and takes time; it cannot be arranged around a sailing date.
- **Compulsory certification.** Certain product categories require the CCC mark. Where it applies, it applies before importation, and a shipment arriving without it is not a documentary problem but a rejected entry.
- **Inspection and quarantine.** Many categories are subject to inspection on entry, with sampling and testing that add time. Build it into the delivery promise rather than discovering it at the port.
- **Labelling.** Chinese-language labelling requirements for consumer and food products are specific and enforced. Agree the label artwork with the buyer in writing and keep the approved version in the order file.

4.8 A screening routine that works everywhere

The six sections above differ in detail and are identical in structure. The routine below takes about fifteen minutes on a new counterparty and almost no time on a repeat one, and it is the single highest-return habit in this guide.

- 27.Screen the parties.** Buyer, consignee, notify party, end user, intermediaries, bank, and — for sensitive lanes — the vessel. Record the date, the lists checked and the result.
- 28.Classify the goods.** Tariff code, and separately: is this dual-use, controlled, or on a high-priority watch list? Classification is a technical question; get engineering to confirm rather than guessing from the sales description.
- 29.Establish the destination and the end use.** Where are the goods going, who will use them, and for what? Note any mismatch between the specification ordered and the stated use.
- 30.Check destination admissibility.** Product marking, registration, certification, labelling and inspection requirements for that market and that product.
- 31.Confirm the money path.** Which bank, which currency, which correspondent. A lawful transaction with no settlement route is not a transaction.
- 32.Write the file note.** Three lines: what you checked, what you found, what you decided. This is what protects you and your company if the transaction is ever questioned.

PRACTICAL EXERCISE Build your country card

For the destination you ship to most, write a single page containing: the origin document you issue and why; the product-compliance marks required; the party who acts as importer of record; the licences or registrations that must exist before shipment; the typical clearance time; and the two things that most often delay a shipment on that lane.

Do this for your top five destinations and you will have replaced most of the questions a five-year veteran answers from memory.

CHAPTER 5

SAP in Export Operations

SAP is not a filing cabinet with a login. It is a chain of linked documents in which each step inherits from the last, and almost every export problem attributed to "the system" is in fact a piece of master data that was wrong before the order was created.

This chapter covers what an export desk actually needs: the document flow, the fields that decide whether your customs and banking documents come out right, and the habits that keep the data clean.

By the end of this chapter you should be able to

- Explain the sales document flow and find where a shipment is stuck without asking IT.
- Identify the fields that drive the export invoice, the declaration and the shipping documents.
- Work with purchasing and warehouse colleagues in their own transactions rather than through e-mail.
- Recognise a master-data problem before it becomes a documentary one.

5.1 The document flow is the whole idea

In SAP, a sale is not one record. It is a sequence — enquiry, quotation, sales order, delivery, goods issue, billing — in which each document copies from its predecessor. Understanding that copying relationship is the difference between fixing a problem and reporting it.

Two consequences follow immediately. First, **an error corrected downstream does not correct itself upstream**: fixing an address on an invoice does not fix the customer master, and the next order will repeat the error. Second, **a document that has already flowed cannot always be changed** — once goods issue is posted, quantities and dates are largely fixed, and correcting them means reversing rather than editing.

Table 5.1 — The export document flow and the usual transactions

Step	What it creates	Typical transaction	What the export desk checks here
Sales order	Commercial commitment	VA01 / VA02 / VA03	Incoterm and named place, payment terms, delivery date, ship-to, plant
Delivery	Picking and shipping document	VL01N / VL02N	Picked quantity, batch, packing, shipping point, route
Packing / handling units	Package structure and weights	VL02N / HU transactions	Gross and net weight — these become the VGM and the packing list
Goods issue	Stock movement and the accounting entry	VL02N (PGI)	Posting date: it drives the shipment date on your documents
Billing	Commercial invoice	VF01 / VF02	Value, currency, description, and the export invoice output
Foreign trade data	Commodity code, origin, procedure	Foreign trade tabs / VI-series	Data that feeds the customs declaration
Freight / transport	Freight order or forwarding order	TM transactions	Carrier, equipment, cut-off dates, freight cost

Transaction codes and screen layouts vary with release, activated components and your company's configuration. Confirm your own landscape; the sequence is universal even where the codes are not.

FIELD NOTE Where is my shipment? — answering it yourself

From the sales order, open the document flow. It shows every subsequent document and its status in one view: whether a delivery exists, whether picking is complete, whether goods issue has been posted, whether billing has run. Ninety per cent of the "where is it?" questions on an export desk are answered there in fifteen seconds, without an e-mail to the warehouse.

The habit to build: **before asking a colleague, look at the flow and ask a narrower question.** "Delivery 80012345 is picked but not goods-issued — is it waiting on the truck or on the inspection?" gets an answer. "Where is my order?" gets a delay.

5.2 The fields that decide your documents

A surprising share of documentary discrepancies are traceable to four data points that were entered once, months earlier, by someone who was not thinking about a letter of credit.

- **Sold-to, ship-to, bill-to and payer.** These are separate partner functions and they print on different documents. A credit that names the applicant's head office while the goods go to a plant needs both, correctly assigned — not one address used everywhere.

- **Incoterm and its location field.** SAP stores the term and the place separately. A term entered without the location produces documents that say "FCA" with no named place, which is not a delivery term and is a discrepancy waiting to be cited.
- **Commodity code and country of origin.** Held on the material master per plant. If they are wrong, they are wrong on the declaration, on the invoice output and on every origin document generated from the system.
- **Weights and units of measure.** Net and gross weight on the material master feed the delivery, the packing list and the verified gross mass. A material with a default weight of one kilogram will produce a packing list nobody can reconcile.

WATCH OUT The material master is a document, not a setting

On most desks the material master is treated as something technical that somebody else owns. In export it is a documentary source: its description, commodity code, origin, weights and packaging data all print. When you find an error there, do not correct the outgoing document and move on — raise the master-data change, then correct the document. Otherwise you will correct the same document every month.

5.3 Working with purchasing and the warehouse

Two things bring an export specialist into the materials side of the system: inward processing, where imported inputs must be traceable to exported outputs, and stock reality, where the confirmed date depends on whether the material actually exists.

- **Purchase orders and goods receipts** establish the origin and the duty status of inputs. Where an inward processing authorisation is in play, the link between the receipt and the eventual export must be demonstrable; that is a data discipline, not a paperwork one.
- **Stock and batch reporting** tells you what is genuinely available, in which plant and in which storage location. Available-to-promise is a calculation, not an observation: understand what your configuration includes before promising against it.
- **Movement history** is the fastest way to answer where a batch went and when — invaluable when a customer disputes a quantity or a claim requires you to trace a specific lot.

5.4 Transport, and the limits of automation

Where a transport management component is in use, freight orders and forwarding orders carry carrier, equipment, dates and cost, and can be linked back to the delivery. That gives you two genuine advantages: freight cost lands on the shipment rather than in a monthly lump, and carrier performance becomes measurable by booking rather than by memory.

What it does not give you is the cut-off. Carrier deadlines change after booking, and the system holds what was entered. Treat the transport document as the record of the plan and the carrier's written confirmation as the record of the deadline — and reconcile them the day before gate-in.

FIELD NOTE If your company runs a trade compliance component

Larger exporters run a dedicated global trade component that screens business partners against sanctions lists, checks licence requirements and blocks documents automatically. When it blocks an order, the correct response is never to find another way to release the shipment. It is to read the block reason, take it to compliance and document the outcome — exactly the routine in §4.8. A screening block that is routinely overridden is worse than no screening at all, because it produces a record showing the company knew.

5.5 Reporting without drowning

Standard reporting will give you far more than you need. Four lists cover the working week on most export desks.

Table 5.2 — Four lists worth having ready

List	What it answers	When to run it
Open sales orders by customer and date	What have we promised and when	Monday, and before any customer call
Deliveries due for shipment	What must physically move this week	Daily
Deliveries with goods issue posted but not billed	What has shipped without an invoice	Daily — this is where documents get forgotten
Billing documents with output errors	Which invoices failed to transmit	Daily; an untransmitted e-invoice is not an invoice

Save each as a personal variant with your own selection criteria. The five minutes spent building the variant is repaid in the first week.

PRACTICAL EXERCISE Trace one order end to end

Take a shipment that has already been delivered and paid. Open the sales order, walk the document flow to the billing document, and write down which field on which document produced each line of the commercial invoice and the packing list.

You will find at least one field you assumed came from somewhere else. That is the field that will surprise you under a letter of credit.

CHAPTER 6

Risk Management and Common Pitfalls

Experienced operators are not people who avoid problems. They are people who recognise a problem early, know roughly what it will cost, and know whether to absorb it or escalate it.

This chapter names the risks an export desk actually carries, gives each one an early signal and a containment move, and ends with the two habits that convert incidents into institutional memory.

By the end of this chapter you should be able to

- Classify a live problem quickly and act on the right axis.
- Judge when to absorb a cost and when to escalate it, and justify the judgement.
- Run a shipment through a pre-mortem before it goes wrong instead of after.
- Write the note that stops the same failure happening to a colleague next quarter.

6.1 A working taxonomy

Export risk is usually discussed as a list of bad outcomes. It is more useful as a list of **places where control is handed over**, because that is where the desk can still act.

Table 6.1 — Where control is handed over, and what it costs when it fails

Handover	Risk that appears	Earliest reliable signal
Quotation accepted	Price no longer covers cost; term is unworkable	Freight requote at booking differs materially from the quoted figure
Order confirmed	Buyer's terms govern; lead time started too early	Buyer references their PO terms in correspondence
Production slot given	Ready date will not hold	Any slip announced by planning, however small
Booking placed	Roll-over; equipment unavailable	Booking confirmation missing vessel name or cut-off
Goods handed to carrier	Cargo damage; risk has passed but payment has not	Driver or terminal raising a condition remark at collection
Documents presented	Discrepancy; delayed or refused payment	Bank acknowledging receipt without comment as day five approaches
Goods arrive	Refusal to take delivery; demurrage	Buyer stops answering after arrival notice
File closed	Blocked VAT refund; unrecoverable input tax	Declaration still open in the system a month after shipment

6.2 Counterparty and payment risk

The largest single loss an export desk can cause is shipping goods that are never paid for. It is almost never a surprise in retrospect: the warning signs are commercial, and they appear before the shipment.

- **A first order that is unusually large.** Credit is extended on a relationship that does not yet exist. Stage the first order, or take an advance.
- **Pressure to ship before the credit is workable.** "Ship now, we will amend the L/C" is a request to give up the protection you priced into the deal.
- **Payment terms renegotiated after production has started.** The leverage has moved and the buyer knows it. This is why lead-time triggers matter (§1.3).
- **A change of consignee or delivery address late in the cycle.** Sometimes routine; sometimes the first visible sign of a diversion or a party you have not screened.
- **Slow acceptance of documents.** A buyer who does not collect documents is a buyer with a cash problem or a market problem.

FIELD NOTE Match the instrument to the risk, not to the habit

- **Advance payment** for new counterparties, small values and difficult jurisdictions.
- **Confirmed documentary credit** where you doubt the issuing bank or the country, not the buyer. Confirmation buys you a bank in a jurisdiction you trust.
- **Unconfirmed credit** where the bank is strong and the country is stable.
- **Documents against payment** only where the transport document is genuinely negotiable (§3.3).
- **Open account** for established relationships — ideally with credit insurance, which also gives you a second opinion on the buyer.

Turkish exporters have access to export credit insurance and financing through Türk Eximbank; where a buyer relationship is growing faster than your comfort, that is the conversation to have with finance rather than a tighter payment term the customer will resist.

6.3 Cargo, transport and the claim you did not preserve

Cargo claims are lost more often through procedure than through cover. Insurers pay when the loss is documented; they decline when the record is silent about when the damage appeared.

33. Note damage on delivery. Under road carriage governed by the CMR convention, apparent damage must be noted at delivery, and there are short deadlines for notice of non-apparent damage. A clean receipt signed by your customer is evidence against you.

34. Photograph before, during and after loading. Container interior, stow, lashing, seal. This costs two minutes and settles most disputes about whether the cargo was stowed properly.

35. Preserve the packaging and the goods. Do not let the consignee dispose of damaged material before a survey; that alone defeats many claims.

36. Notify the insurer immediately, even before the extent is known, and notify the carrier in writing within the time limit in the transport contract.

37. Keep the survey report and the repair or replacement costing together with the original commercial documents. A claim file assembled six weeks later is missing exactly the documents that mattered.

6.4 Documentary risk

Chapter 3 covered how documents work. The risk view is simpler: **the cost of a discrepancy is not the discrepancy fee, it is the delay and the loss of leverage.** Once documents are refused, the buyer can accept them, negotiate on them, or wait — and the goods are usually already at their port.

- Build the set from the credit rather than the order, and do it the day the credit arrives.
- Have a colleague check the set against the credit — not the person who prepared it. Cross-checking finds errors that re-reading does not.
- Ask the advising bank for an informal pre-check when the value is large. Many will do it, and it is far cheaper than a refusal.
- When a discrepancy is unavoidable, tell the buyer before the bank does, and ask for a waiver in advance. A discrepancy the buyer already agreed to waive is an administrative step; one they learn about from their bank is a negotiation.

6.5 The human failures that produce most incidents

The incidents that recur on export desks are rarely exotic. Four patterns account for most of them.

Table 6.2 — Four recurring failure patterns

Pattern	What it looks like	Countermeasure
Information that does not cross a boundary	A date change known in sales on Monday, discovered by logistics on Thursday	A standing rule: any date change is communicated the day it is known (\$1.4)
Data retyped instead of generated	Weights and seal numbers keyed separately into three documents	One data source per shipment; documents generated, not typed
Verbal agreements with carriers and brokers	"They said they would hold the booking"	Written confirmation of vessel, cut-off and free time on every booking

Pattern	What it looks like	Countermeasure
Silence treated as agreement	No answer from bank, carrier or customer read as "fine"	The four silences in §1.6, chased rather than waited out

FIELD NOTE Absorb or escalate?

Junior specialists escalate too late, then over-correct and escalate everything. Three questions settle it quickly.

- **Is the cost bounded and within my authority?** A courier fee, a day of detention, a small re-work — absorb, record, move on.
- **Does the fix require someone else to change a commitment?** A production slot, a credit amendment, a price — escalate, because you cannot deliver it alone.
- **Could this become a legal, compliance or reputational matter?** Sanctions, a false declaration, a safety issue, a customer alleging breach — escalate immediately and in writing, regardless of size.

The third category has no discretion attached to it. Escalating it is not an admission that you could not handle it; not escalating it is the mistake.

6.6 Building the desk's memory

Everything in this guide is compressed experience. The reason experience is normally slow to accumulate is that it is stored in individuals and leaves when they do. Two lightweight habits fix that.

38. The incident note. After any shipment that went wrong, write five lines: what happened, when it first became visible, what it cost, what would have caught it earlier, what changed as a result. File them in one place. A year of these is a better training manual than anything bought externally.

39. The pre-mortem. Before a shipment that is unusual — new market, new product, first order with a customer, unusual delivery term — spend ten minutes with the question: *"It is six weeks from now and this went badly. What happened?"* Write the three most likely answers and act on the cheapest one.

PRACTICAL EXERCISE Run a pre-mortem on your next unusual shipment

Take the next order that differs from your routine. Write the three most likely failures, the earliest signal for each, and one preventive action per failure that costs less than an hour. Keep the sheet and review it after the shipment closes.

Over a year this exercise builds the thing this whole guide is trying to transfer: not knowledge of procedures, but a calibrated sense of what usually goes wrong and how early it can be seen.

Appendix A — Incoterms® 2020 Quick Reference

A.1 The eleven rules at a glance

The table below is an aid to memory for people who already know the rules. It is not a substitute for the ICC text, which is the only authority and which your desk should own.

Table A.1 — Cost and risk allocation

Rule	Mode	Risk passes to buyer	Seller pays carriage to	Export / import clearance
EXW	Any	At seller's premises	Nothing	Buyer / buyer
FCA	Any	On delivery to buyer's carrier	Named place only	Seller / buyer
FAS	Sea / inland waterway	Alongside the vessel	Quay at port of shipment	Seller / buyer
FOB	Sea / inland waterway	On board the vessel	Port of shipment	Seller / buyer
CFR	Sea / inland waterway	On board the vessel	Named port of destination	Seller / buyer
CIF	Sea / inland waterway	On board the vessel	Named port of destination + insurance (min. ICC C)	Seller / buyer
CPT	Any	On handover to first carrier	Named place of destination	Seller / buyer
CIP	Any	On handover to first carrier	Named place + insurance (min. ICC A)	Seller / buyer
DAP	Any	At destination, ready for unloading	Named place of destination	Seller / buyer
DPU	Any	At destination, after unloading	Named place, unloaded	Seller / buyer
DDP	Any	At destination, cleared for import	Named place, duty paid	Seller / seller

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A.2 Five things people get wrong

- **Incoterms do not determine when title passes.** Title is a matter for the sale contract and the governing law.
- **They do not set payment terms.** CIF does not mean the buyer pays on arrival.
- **FOB is for bulk and break-bulk, not containers.** For containers handed over at a terminal, FCA reflects reality.
- **A rule without a named place is incomplete,** and a named place that is a country rather than a point is nearly as bad.
- **Only CIF and CIP oblige the seller to insure,** and they require different minimum covers.

Appendix B — Classification: Working with HS Codes

B.1 What the code has to survive

A commodity code is a legal assertion about what the goods are. It determines duty at destination, whether a licence or certificate is needed, whether a trade defence measure applies, and whether the shipment attracts scrutiny. It also has to be defensible years later, in a post-clearance audit, by someone who has never seen the product.

B.2 A workable classification method

- 40. Describe the product physically**, not commercially: material, function, degree of processing, presentation. Marketing language classifies nothing.
- 41. Work down the structure** — chapter, heading, subheading — applying the General Rules of Interpretation in order rather than searching for a familiar word.
- 42. Check the section and chapter notes.** They exclude more than they include and they are binding, not advisory.
- 43. Compare against the explanatory notes** and, where they exist, published classification decisions for similar goods.
- 44. Record the reasoning**, not just the code. Three lines explaining why heading X and not heading Y is what protects the classification later.
- 45. Reconcile with the destination code** your buyer will declare. Beyond the first six digits, national codes diverge, and a divergence is worth knowing about before shipment (§4.7).

FIELD NOTE When you are genuinely unsure

Do not guess and do not adopt the buyer's code because it is convenient. Two routes exist: ask your customs broker for a written opinion, or apply for a binding tariff decision from the customs administration. A binding decision takes time but ends the argument, and for a product you will ship for years it is cheap.

WATCH OUT The two classification errors that cost most

- **Classifying to the duty you want.** A code chosen because it carries a lower rate is a misdeclaration; the retroactive assessment lands on your customer and the relationship does not survive it.
- **Letting the code drift from the product.** A material master coded correctly in 2019 for a product that has since changed its composition is now wrong, quietly, on every shipment.

Appendix C — Glossary

Table C.1 — Terms used in this guide

Term	Meaning
A.TR	Movement certificate evidencing free circulation status in the EU–Türkiye Customs Union. Not a proof of origin.
AEO / YYS	Authorised economic operator; in Türkiye, <i>Yetkilendirilmiş Yükümlü Sertifikası</i> . Brings simplified customs procedures.
ATA carnet	International customs document for temporary admission of goods such as samples and exhibition material.
CAD	Cash against documents; a documentary collection in which documents are released against payment.
CBAM	The EU carbon border adjustment mechanism, which attaches an emissions cost to imports of covered goods.
CMR	The convention governing international carriage of goods by road, and the consignment note issued under it.
Cut-off	The carrier's deadline — separately for documentation, verified gross mass and gate-in — before a sailing.
Demurrage / detention	Charges for keeping a container beyond free time inside the terminal (demurrage) or outside it (detention).
Discrepancy	A defect in documents presented under a documentary credit, entitling the bank to refuse.
EUR.1	Movement certificate evidencing preferential origin under a free trade agreement.
GÇB	<i>Gümrük Çıkış Beyannamesi</i> — the Turkish export customs declaration.
HS code	Harmonised System commodity code; internationally harmonised to six digits, extended nationally beyond that.
Incoterms®	ICC rules allocating cost, risk and obligations between seller and buyer in a sale of goods.
Inward processing	Regime allowing duty relief on imported inputs that are processed and re-exported.
ISPM 15	International standard requiring treatment and marking of solid wood packaging material.
L/C	Documentary credit; a bank undertaking to pay against complying documents, governed in practice by UCP 600.
Roll-over	The carrier moving a booked container to a later sailing.
UCP 600	The ICC Uniform Customs and Practice for Documentary Credits, 2007 revision.
URC 522	The ICC Uniform Rules for Collections, governing documentary collections.
VGM	Verified gross mass of a packed container, required under SOLAS before loading.

Appendix D — Where to Check: Primary Sources

Nothing in this guide should be relied on without checking the source. The list below is what an export desk should have bookmarked; it is deliberately short, because a source you actually open beats ten you have collected.

Table D.1 — What to check where

Question	Authoritative source
Turkish export procedure, licences, regime decisions	Ministry of Trade (Ticaret Bakanlığı)
Tariff classification, customs procedure, authorised operator status	Turkish customs administration and the integrated tariff system
VAT exemption and refund procedure	Revenue Administration (Gelir İdaresi Başkanlığı)
Repatriation of export proceeds	The current export circular (<i>İhracat Genelgesi</i>) and your bank
Exporters' association registration and sector data	Turkish Exporters Assembly (TİM) and the relevant exporters' association
Export credit, guarantees and buyer credit insurance	Türk Eximbank
Incoterms®, UCP 600, URC 522 texts	International Chamber of Commerce publications
EU tariff, measures, and product legislation	The EU integrated tariff database and the Official Journal
UK tariff, origin rules and product marking	UK government trade tariff and guidance
US tariff, entry requirements and sanctions listings	US Customs and Border Protection; OFAC sanctions lists
EAEU technical regulations and conformity	Eurasian Economic Commission
Chinese product registration and inspection	General Administration of Customs of China (GACC)

Where a rule can change, this guide has said so. Where it has not said so, assume it can change anyway and check.

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ATA carnet §3.6
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